

Mental Health Resources

Guide

Understanding Mental Health

Mental health includes our emotional, psychological, and social well-being. It affects how we think, feel, act, handle stress, relate to others, and make choices. Mental health is important at every stage of life.

Common Mental Health Conditions

Depression

Symptoms:

- Persistent sad, anxious, or "empty" mood
- Loss of interest in activities once enjoyed
- Changes in appetite or weight
- Sleep disturbances (insomnia or oversleeping)
- Fatigue or loss of energy
- Feelings of worthlessness or guilt
- Difficulty concentrating
- Thoughts of death or suicide

When to Seek Help:

- Symptoms persist for more than 2 weeks
- Symptoms interfere with daily life
- Thoughts of self-harm or suicide

Treatment Options:

- Psychotherapy (talk therapy)
- Medication (antidepressants)
- Lifestyle changes
- Support groups
- Combination approaches

Anxiety Disorders

Types:

- Generalized Anxiety Disorder (GAD)
- Panic Disorder
- Social Anxiety Disorder
- Specific Phobias
- Obsessive-Compulsive Disorder (OCD)
- Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)

Common Symptoms:

- Excessive worry or fear
- Restlessness or feeling on edge
- Rapid heartbeat
- Sweating or trembling
- Difficulty concentrating
- Sleep problems
- Avoidance behaviors

Treatment Options:

- Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)
- Exposure therapy
- Medication (anti-anxiety medications, antidepressants)
- Relaxation techniques
- Mindfulness practices

Bipolar Disorder

Symptoms:

- **Manic Episodes:** Elevated mood, increased energy, decreased need for sleep, risky behavior
- **Depressive Episodes:** Similar to major depression
- Mood swings between extremes

Treatment:

- Mood stabilizers
- Psychotherapy
- Lifestyle management
- Support groups

Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)

Symptoms:

- Intrusive memories or flashbacks

- Avoidance of trauma reminders
- Negative changes in thoughts and mood
- Hyperarousal (easily startled, tense)
- Nightmares

Treatment:

- Trauma-focused therapy
- EMDR (Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing)
- Medication
- Support groups

Eating Disorders

Types:

- Anorexia Nervosa
- Bulimia Nervosa
- Binge Eating Disorder

Warning Signs:

- Preoccupation with weight, food, calories
- Extreme dietary restrictions
- Binge eating
- Purging behaviors
- Excessive exercise
- Distorted body image

Treatment:

- Medical monitoring
- Nutritional counseling
- Psychotherapy
- Medication (for co-occurring conditions)
- Family therapy

Self-Care Strategies

Daily Mental Health Practices

1. Physical Health

- Exercise regularly (30 minutes most days)
- Eat balanced, nutritious meals

- Get 7-9 hours of sleep
- Limit alcohol and avoid drugs
- Stay hydrated

2. Stress Management

- Practice deep breathing exercises
- Try progressive muscle relaxation
- Engage in meditation or mindfulness
- Use time management techniques
- Set realistic goals and priorities

3. Social Connection

- Maintain relationships with friends and family
- Join clubs or groups with shared interests
- Volunteer in your community
- Reach out when you need support
- Limit social media if it causes stress

4. Meaningful Activities

- Engage in hobbies you enjoy
- Spend time in nature
- Practice gratitude
- Help others
- Learn new skills

5. Mental Stimulation

- Read books
- Solve puzzles
- Learn something new
- Engage in creative activities
- Limit screen time

Mindfulness and Meditation

Benefits:

- Reduces stress and anxiety
- Improves focus and concentration
- Enhances emotional regulation
- Promotes better sleep
- Increases self-awareness

Simple Mindfulness Exercise:

1. Find a quiet space
2. Sit comfortably
3. Focus on your breath
4. Notice when mind wanders
5. Gently return focus to breath
6. Start with 5 minutes, gradually increase

Mindfulness Apps:

- Headspace
- Calm
- Insight Timer
- Ten Percent Happier

Journaling

Benefits:

- Process emotions
- Track mood patterns
- Identify triggers
- Set and track goals
- Practice gratitude

Prompts:

- What am I grateful for today?
- What challenges did I face and how did I handle them?
- What are my goals for tomorrow?
- How am I feeling right now and why?
- What brought me joy today?

Crisis Resources

Immediate Help

National Suicide Prevention Lifeline

- **Phone:** 988 (24/7)
- **Chat:** 988lifeline.org
- Free, confidential support

Crisis Text Line

- **Text:** HOME to 741741 (24/7)

- Free crisis counseling via text

SAMHSA National Helpline

- **Phone:** 1-800-662-4357 (24/7)
- Treatment referral and information service

Veterans Crisis Line

- **Phone:** 988, then press 1
- **Text:** 838255
- **Chat:** veteranscrisisline.net

Trevor Project (LGBTQ Youth)

- **Phone:** 1-866-488-7386
- **Text:** START to 678678
- **Chat:** thetrevorproject.org

RAINN (Sexual Assault)

- **Phone:** 1-800-656-4673 (24/7)
- **Chat:** online.rainn.org

Warning Signs of Crisis

Seek Immediate Help If:

- Thinking about suicide or self-harm
- Making plans to end life
- Giving away possessions
- Saying goodbye to loved ones
- Feeling hopeless or trapped
- Experiencing unbearable pain
- Talking about being a burden

What to Do:

1. Call 988 or 911 immediately
2. Don't leave person alone
3. Remove access to means of self-harm
4. Listen without judgment
5. Encourage professional help
6. Follow up and stay connected

Finding Professional Help

Types of Mental Health Professionals

Psychiatrist

- Medical doctor (MD or DO)
- Can prescribe medication
- Treats mental health conditions

Psychologist

- Doctoral degree (PhD or PsyD)
- Provides psychotherapy
- Conducts psychological testing

Licensed Clinical Social Worker (LCSW)

- Master's degree in social work
- Provides therapy and case management
- Connects to community resources

Licensed Professional Counselor (LPC)

- Master's degree in counseling
- Provides individual and group therapy
- Specializes in specific issues

Psychiatric Nurse Practitioner

- Advanced nursing degree
- Can prescribe medication
- Provides therapy

How to Find a Therapist

1. Get Referrals

- Ask primary care doctor
- Contact insurance company
- Ask trusted friends or family
- Check with employee assistance program (EAP)

2. Online Directories

- Psychology Today ([psychologytoday.com](https://www.psychologytoday.com))
- SAMHSA Treatment Locator (findtreatment.gov)
- National Alliance on Mental Illness ([nami.org](https://www.nami.org))
- American Psychological Association ([apa.org](https://www.apa.org))

3. Consider These Factors

- Specialization and expertise
- Treatment approach
- Insurance acceptance
- Location and availability
- Cultural competency
- Personal comfort level

4. Questions to Ask

- What is your experience with my specific concern?
- What treatment approach do you use?
- How long is each session?
- What are your fees?
- Do you accept my insurance?
- What is your cancellation policy?

Teletherapy Options

Benefits:

- Convenient and accessible
- Reduced travel time
- More scheduling flexibility
- Comfortable home environment

Popular Platforms:

- BetterHelp
- Talkspace
- MDLive
- Amwell
- Doctor on Demand

Supporting Others

How to Help Someone Struggling

Do:

- Listen without judgment
- Express concern and support
- Ask directly about suicide if concerned
- Encourage professional help
- Offer to help find resources

- Check in regularly
- Be patient
- Take care of yourself too

Don't:

- Minimize their feelings
- Give unsolicited advice
- Try to "fix" them
- Make it about you
- Force them to talk
- Break confidentiality (unless safety risk)
- Give up on them

Conversation Starters

- "I've noticed you seem down lately. How are you doing?"
 - "I'm worried about you. Can we talk?"
 - "You seem stressed. Is there anything I can do to help?"
 - "I'm here for you whenever you need to talk."
 - "Have you thought about talking to someone professional?"
-

Workplace Mental Health

Recognizing Burnout

Symptoms:

- Exhaustion and fatigue
- Cynicism or detachment
- Reduced productivity
- Lack of motivation
- Irritability
- Physical symptoms (headaches, stomach issues)

Prevention:

- Set boundaries between work and personal life
- Take regular breaks
- Use vacation time
- Communicate with supervisor
- Practice stress management
- Seek support when needed

Workplace Accommodations

Possible Accommodations:

- Flexible schedule
- Remote work options
- Quiet workspace
- Modified break schedule
- Reduced workload during difficult periods
- Time off for appointments

How to Request:

- Know your rights (ADA protections)
 - Document your needs
 - Speak with HR or supervisor
 - Provide medical documentation if needed
 - Be specific about what would help
-

Mental Health and Physical Health

The Mind-Body Connection

Physical Health Impacts Mental Health:

- Chronic illness can lead to depression
- Pain affects mood and quality of life
- Sleep problems worsen mental health
- Nutrition affects brain function

Mental Health Impacts Physical Health:

- Stress weakens immune system
- Depression increases heart disease risk
- Anxiety can cause physical symptoms
- Mental health affects health behaviors

Integrated Care

Benefits:

- Treats whole person
- Better health outcomes
- Improved quality of life
- Reduced healthcare costs

Components:

- Primary care and mental health coordination
 - Medication management
 - Lifestyle interventions
 - Regular monitoring
-

Special Populations

Children and Adolescents

Warning Signs:

- Changes in school performance
- Withdrawal from friends and activities
- Excessive worry or fear
- Frequent tantrums or irritability
- Changes in eating or sleeping
- Physical complaints without medical cause
- Self-harm or risky behaviors

Resources:

- School counselor
- Pediatrician
- Child psychologist
- Family therapy

Older Adults

Unique Challenges:

- Loss and grief
- Chronic health conditions
- Isolation and loneliness
- Cognitive changes
- Life transitions

Resources:

- Geriatric psychiatrist
- Senior centers
- Support groups
- Area Agency on Aging

LGBTQ+ Community

Specific Concerns:

- Discrimination and stigma
- Family rejection
- Identity development
- Higher rates of depression and anxiety

Resources:

- Trevor Project
 - GLBT National Hotline: 1-888-843-4564
 - LGBTQ-affirming therapists
 - Community centers
-

Insurance and Financial Resources

Understanding Coverage

Check Your Insurance:

- Mental health benefits
- In-network providers
- Copays and deductibles
- Session limits
- Prior authorization requirements

Mental Health Parity:

- Federal law requires equal coverage for mental and physical health
- Insurance must cover mental health at same level as medical care

Low-Cost Options

Community Mental Health Centers

- Sliding scale fees based on income
- Comprehensive services
- Find: SAMHSA Treatment Locator

University Training Clinics

- Supervised graduate students
- Reduced fees

- Quality care

Non-Profit Organizations

- NAMI (National Alliance on Mental Illness)
- Mental Health America
- Local community organizations

Online Resources

- Free support groups
 - Self-help apps
 - Educational materials
 - Peer support forums
-

Recovery and Wellness

Recovery Principles

Recovery is:

- Possible for everyone
- Person-driven
- Holistic (mind, body, spirit)
- Supported by peers and allies
- Based on respect
- Culturally sensitive

Recovery Involves:

- Hope and empowerment
- Self-determination
- Meaningful activities
- Supportive relationships
- Addressing trauma
- Building strengths

Wellness Plan Components

1. Daily Maintenance

- Activities that keep you well
- Support system
- Triggers to avoid

2. Early Warning Signs

- Subtle changes indicating decline
- Action plan for early intervention

3. Crisis Plan

- Warning signs of crisis
- Emergency contacts
- Preferred treatments
- What helps and what doesn't

4. Post-Crisis Plan

- Recovery activities
- Gradual return to routine
- Ongoing support

Important Reminders

⚠ **Medical Disclaimer:** This guide is for educational purposes only and does not replace professional mental health care. Always consult qualified mental health professionals for diagnosis and treatment.

☐ **Crisis Help:** If you or someone you know is in crisis, call 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline) or 911 immediately.

☐ **You Are Not Alone:** Millions of people experience mental health challenges. Help is available, and recovery is possible.

☐ **Seeking Help is Strength:** Taking care of your mental health is as important as taking care of your physical health.

Last Updated: 2026 Source: General mental health information and resources